

TECHNOLOGY REVIEW: VOLKSWAGEN PASSAT

THE PRIVILEGE OF COMFORT

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Often, summing up reviews within the confines of print boundaries become a tedious task. This saying holds true for a certain few cars, which literally offer more bells and whistles than what you may ever tinker with if you end up buying it. Then, there are certain cars that do not come with an overwhelming load of features, but still end up offering exactly as much to talk about. Case in hand - the new generation Volkswagen Passat.

The new Passat is exactly what it has always been – a full-size executive saloon with loads of space inside, taut angles, a monolithic boot, and precision-engineered interiors and equipment array. With the new one, you get even sharper lines than before, particularly along the front and the window sill, and considerably longer wheelbase than Audi's entry-segment sedan – the A3.

But it is the technology that we're focussing on here. Peeking inside the Passat, you'd be forgiven for thinking that this is as straightforward a car as they come. The dash is neatly layered with horizontal continuous vents, and the flow is broken only by an analogue clock and a large, 8-inch infotainment system. When you step inside the Passat for the first time and look at this display, you can be a bit disappointed. It does not look particularly high fidelity, has a matte touch panel, and the dark colour theme with dimmed icons do not make it the liveliest display to look at. In today's world of multi-colour HUDs and supremely crisp in-car displays, this feels rather out-of-place, particularly in this segment of cars.

But, this SmartLink+ system is fluid and responsive to touch, has a wonderful smoothness to its operations and hosts a wide range of features. The list begins with a proximity sensor for

gauging touch feedback, Bluetooth and USB for audio streaming and telephony, Android Auto, Apple CarPlay and MirrorLink, and a media browser for accessing images when the car is static. It also gets driver fatigue alert system for alerting the driver via haptics, and the ThinkBlue trainer that gives you a rating based on how well you've driven, anticipated throttle and braking, and the overall mileage. Strangely, the Passat does not come with a native navigation system, and only with Android Auto can users get Google Maps loaded on to the system.

Yet another less-inspiring element about the Passat is the audio system. At this segment, you'd expect the audio system to be co-branded by a premium manufacturer. The Passat gets white label speakers, which do not sound too bad. While the delivery of bass, mids and treble is well balanced, they lack a certain level of theatricality, which